

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Verbs 1

The things verbs do



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Verb. It's what you do. At least, that's what those old commercials told us. Verbs are an essential part of language, representing the action, state or event going on in whatever is being communicated. A verb

takes a number of nouns as arguments and relates them as each having a certain role in an event. As the word most closely describing the event, they also tend to carry information about when the event is happening, how it's happening, and who it's happening to. In this lesson we'll talk about the different things verbs tend to show and some features to consider when working on verbs for your conlang.

Valency & transitivity

Verbs differ in how many arguments they have. The number of arguments a verb has is its **valency**. A verb with one possible argument is called **monovalent**. An example of a monovalent verb is "to sleep." In the sentence "Martha was already sleeping," there is only one participant in the action and the verb can only take a single argument. In languages which use stative verbs instead of adjectives, these tend to be monovalent predicates. For example, in sentence (1), from Cantonese (Sinitic, Sino-Tibetan), the adjective phrase is essentially a monovalent verb phrase. Even though it doesn't describe an action, it still makes an assertion with one single participant.

```
1. lei5 hou2 leng3 aa3
   2sg very beautiful EMPH
   "You are very beautiful."
```

A verb with two arguments is **divalent**. Generally these are verbs with one subject and one object. In the sentence "We love Martha," the verb "to love" takes two arguments, "we" and "Martha." A verb may also have three arguments, in which case it is **trivalent**. A typical example of a trivalent verb is "to give." For example in the sentence "Martha gave Alice a flowerpot," the verb has three arguments: a giver "Martha," a recipient "Alice," and an object being given, "a flowerpot." All three of those are core participants. Less commonly, some languages have **tetravalent** verbs with four arguments. One possible example of a tetravalent verb is a trivalent verb like "to give" with an added argument who's causing the action. A language might treat all of the participants of a sentence like "The police made me return the cookies to the bakery," as arguments, and the verb might agree with all four of them. It's possible for a verb to have no arguments at all, in which case it is called **avalent**. English doesn't really have any avalent verbs, so here is an example from Portuguese (Romance, Indo-European).

```
2. está chove-ndo
   be.3s.PRS rain -GER
   "It is raining."
```

In Portuguese, the verb *chover* doesn't take any arguments, not even a subject. Unlike in English, where you have a dummy pronoun "it" as your subject, in Portuguese, you can't add in a subject. The verb has zero arguments and it's ungrammatical to have any more.

While a verb's valency is its overall number of arguments, its **transitivity** is its number of non-subject arguments. Generally, a predicate's transitivity is one less than its valency. An **intransitive** verb is one that has zero non-subject arguments. Just a subject. In the examples before, the verb "to sleep" as in "Martha was already sleeping" has no object, so it is intransitive. A verb with one object that is completely distinct from the subject is **transitive**. In the sentence "Martha takes a piece of falafel," "to take" is a transitive verb. A verb with two objects is **ditransitive**, for example the verb "to give" in "Martha gives Alice a flowerpot."

It's important to remember that verb transitivity might differ between languages. You've already seen the difference between intransitive "It's raining," and completely avalent "Está chovendo." Another thing to think about is that some verbs can take objects directly, but others need them to be in prepositional phrases. English has transitive "to discuss a story" but "to listen *to* a story," where you can't have a plain object, only a prepositional phrase. French (Romance, Indo-European) reverses that. Discussing requires a preposition "discuter *d'*une histoire" whereas listening does not "écouter une histoire."

Sometimes the role that maps to the subject in one language will map to the object in another. Compare English's "I like the apples", Spanish's "*Me gustan las manzanas*," Portuguese's "*Eu gosto das maçãs*," and Irish's (Celtic, Indo-European) "*Is maith liom na húlla*," four ways of saying the same thing.

```
3a. me      gust-an las      manzanas
    1S.DAT like-3P the.F.PL apples

b. eu      gost-o d- as      maçãs
    1S.NOM like-1S of-the.F.PL apples

c. is maith liom      na húlla
    be good with.me the apples

    "I like the apples."
```

One role, the "liker," is the subject in English and Portuguese, but the indirect object in Spanish and the object of a preposition in Irish. The other role, the "likee" is a direct object in English, the subject in Spanish and Irish, and a prepositional object in Portuguese. (If you don't believe me that the apples are the subject in Spanish, check out the verb marking. There's a suffix saying that the subject is third-person plural, so it can't be "me," it's gotta be "apples"!) When you're creating your language, remember that verbs expressing the same thing can have different transitivities or put the same role into different positions. Read up on how natlangs do it and get creative!

Agreement

Agreement is when a word changes its form to match a feature of another word. Verbs often agree with their arguments, most commonly with the subject. Verbs most commonly agree with the person, gender, and number of their arguments. **Person** refers to who is doing an action: first person includes the speaker, second person includes the listener, and third person includes neither. **Gender** refers to the grammatical class that a noun or pronoun is in. This goes beyond just masculine, feminine, and neuter, as you'll learn in the next lesson. **Number** refers to how many of something there is. Most commonly singular (for just one) and plural (for more than one), but sometimes also dual (exactly two) or paucal (a few).

We'll start close to home. Present-tense English verbs agree with their subject: if the subject is singular and third person, then they take the suffix -s. Compare "I walk" with "He walks." This is just about it for English, but many languages' verbs have larger agreement paradigms. For example, in Portuguese, verbs always agree in both number and person with the subject.

```
4. Eu chego hoje, ela chega amanhã, e os outros chegam na quinta.
   eu cheg -o      hoje ela  cheg -a      amanhã
   1S arrive-1S.PRS today 3S.FEM arrive-3S.PRS tomorrow
   e os      outros      cheg-am      na quinta
   and the.M.PL others.M.PL arrive-3PL.PRS on.the Thursday
   "I arrive today, she arrives tomorrow, and the others arrive on Thursday."
```

The same verb root "*cheg-*" 'arrive' takes a different affix for each person/number/tense combination. When agreement clearly indicates the person doing an action, pronouns can often be omitted without ambiguity. Portuguese *chego* unambiguously means "I arrive" so you don't need to include the first-person singular pronoun *eu* unless it's stressed.

In some languages, different verb forms can agree with different things. For example in many Slavic languages, all forms agree with person and number of the subject, but only past tense forms agree with the gender of the subject. Take these examples from Croatian (Slavic, Indo-European). The past tense verbs have to agree with the subject's gender, but the present tense ones do not. (Note that Marko is a male name and Ana is a female name in Croatian.)

```
5. Marko vidi Anu i Ana vidi Marka.
   Marko   vid-i   Anu   i   Ana   vid-i   Marka
   Marko.NOM see-3S.PRS Ana.ACC and Ana.NOM see-3S.PRS Marko.ACC
   "Marko sees Ana and Ana sees Marko."

6. Marko je vidio Anu i Ana je vidjela Marka.
   Marko   je   vid-io   Anu   i   Ana   je   vid-jela   Marka
   Marko.NOM AUX.3S see-S.M.PST Ana.ACC and Ana.NOM AUX.3S see-S.F.PST Marko.ACC
   "Marko saw Ana and Ana saw Marko."
```

Although subject agreement is most common, agreement is not at all limited to the subject. Many languages agree with more than one argument in the sentence, a phenomenon known as **polypersonal agreement**. Here's an example from Luganda (Bantu, Niger-Congo), where verb agrees with both the gender III subject and the gender I object.

```
7. Embuzi emunywa kaawa.  
em- buzi e-      mu-   nywa kaawa  
III-goat III.SBJ-I.OBJ-drink coffee.I  
"The goat is drinking coffee."
```

When you're building your conlang, you can be as creative as you want. Agree with gender, person, and number of subject, direct object, and indirect object, or agree with nothing at all! Think about what categories are important in your language and how, if at all, they might get cross-referenced on verbs. Then knowing what information you have on verbs, think about what information you do or don't have to put in the rest of the sentence.

Tense & aspect

Tense and aspect are easily confused: both refer to an event's relationship with time. It doesn't help that the things traditional grammars call "tense" are really mixes of tense, aspect, and something else called "mood." In order to understand what tense and aspect really are, it helps to define a few points on a timeline. First, there's the **utterance time**, affectionately known as UT. The UT is when the speaker is actually uttering a sentence. From their perspective, it's right now. Then, there's the **event time** (ET) which is the time that an event happened. Last, there's the **reference time** (RT) which is some point in time that is relevant or prominent in the conversation. The RT can be the same as the ET, but importantly it doesn't have to be.

Tense is a form that marks the relationship between the reference time and the utterance time, that is, it shows when something happened relative to *right now*, whenever the speaker uttered the sentence. If the RT coincides with the UT, then the event is relevant as the speaker says the sentence. A tense that marks this is the **present**. If the RT comes before the UT, then the point in time we care about already happened. A tense marking this is **past**. If the RT comes after the UT...you get where this is going: a tense marking that is the **future**. Here's a timeline for the three most common tenses:

```
Past:      <----RT----UT----->

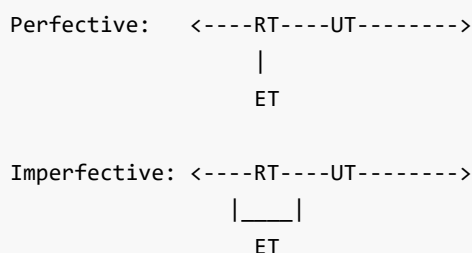
Present:   <-----UT/RT----->

Future:    <-----UT----RT---->
```

Some languages have even more divisions, with a specific remote past tense for when the RT is very *very* far before the UT or a recent past tense for when the RT is earlier in the same day as the UT. The thing that all tenses have in common is that they describe when the speaker is talking about, relative to the moment the sentence is uttered. It doesn't matter when or how long, as long as you know how it's situated relative to the UT.

Although they're often conflated, aspect is distinct from tense. An **aspect** is some form that marks how the event time sits on the timeline relative to reference time. While tense marks where in time the speaker is talking about, aspect marks how an event extends over it.

A common distinction is between perfective and imperfective aspects. The **perfective** aspect describes an action seen as a single point in time. Its event time is completely contained within the reference time and is not seen as having duration. This contrasts with the **imperfective**, which describes an event whose time extends beyond the reference time, and is seen as having duration.



In the sentence "I was listening to the radio when the phone rang," there are two events: "me listening to the radio" and "the phone ringing." At the moment under consideration, I had been listening to the radio already and will probably continue listening to the radio. The action has duration and extends beyond the reference time, so it would be imperfective. The phone, on the other hand, rang instantaneously at the point on the timeline we're thinking about. The event of the phone ringing lies entirely within the reference time, so it would be perfective. We can see this in English: the progressive form "was listening" is an imperfective past tense and the simple past form "rang" is (usually) a perfective past tense. And it's not just English. This split is common across languages.

Many languages make even more distinctions. English has a construction where "used to" with an infinitive marks a **habitual** aspect, *i.e.* one where an event occurs commonly around the reference time. English only marks the habitual in the past tense, but that's not unusual. Languages often have more aspect distinctions in the past tense than other tenses. Some languages have a **prospective** aspect for an event that's about to happen at the reference time or an **iterative** aspect for an event that happened repeatedly at different time points around the reference time. Others mark events that begin at the reference time with the **inchoative** or events that end at the reference time with the **cessative**. You can be creative! But note one thing all these aspects have in common: they only relate to the reference time, not the utterance time. You can just as easily have past prospective and cessative as future prospective and cessative! We'll get deeper into aspect in future lessons.

Perfect & perfective

This part was written by Priscianic

You might have seen people talk about "perfects" and "perfectives", and wondered what they were and whether they're the same or not. It's understandably confusing terminology! However, perfect and perfective actually refer to different kinds of aspects. We've already seen what the perfective aspect does: it asserts that the event time is contained inside the reference time. The perfect, in contrast, seems to do something different: it seems to assert that the event time precedes the reference time. So let's see some English examples to get a feel for what this difference is:

- i. I went to the grocery store. (past perfective)
- ii. I have gone to the grocery store. (present perfect)

In (i), we have a past perfective, and we're asserting the the interval of time in which I went to the grocery store is contained within the reference time (some contextually-salient past time). In (ii), we have a

present perfect, and we're asserting that the interval of time in which I went to the grocery store precedes a present reference time (i.e. it happened before now). You can tell that the perfect have gone is actually present tense because have is in its present tense form (the past tense of have is had).

You can also have past perfects (also known as pluperfects); these assert that the event time precedes some salient past reference time:

iii. I had gone to the grocery store.

Here you can tell that it's past because you have the past tense form of have: had.

An additional thing to note about perfects is that they seem to generally also convey a sense of "present relevance" (or past relevance, in the case of past perfects), or that the result state of the event in question extends into the present (or past, in the case of past perfects). For instance, in English, it's weird to use the perfect if you went shopping, came back home, realized you forgot something, and returned to the store. Here's an example (the # marks semantic/pragmatic weirdness):

iv. [Context: You want to buy apples and bananas. You went to the grocery store earlier this morning, but only bought apples. You then came home. Later, in the afternoon, you notice that you don't have any bananas, and realize that you forgot to buy any. So you go back to the store. While at the store, you say:]

a. ✓I came here this morning, but I forgot to buy bananas, so I'm back.

(past perfective)

b. #I have come here this morning, but I forgot to buy bananas, so I'm back.

(present perfect)

If all that the perfect aspect conveyed was that the event time precedes the reference time, then (b) should be acceptable in this context, since it is in fact true that the time at which you came to the grocery store this morning precedes the present reference time. So this indicates that there's also some kind of current relevance/resultative inference with perfects as well.

Mood

Another common feature of verb inflections is mood. **Mood** is a category that reflects a speaker's view on the truth of an event. Inflecting a verb for mood can tell you whether the speaker thinks something is true, things something may be true, wishes it were true, or wants you to make it true.

Moods are broadly split into two categories: **realis** which describes an event that the speaker knows to be true, and **irrealis** which describes an event that the speaker does not know to be true. The default realis mood, used when making a statement of fact is known as the **indicative** mood. This entire paragraph is written in the indicative mood.

All certain things are certain, but uncertain things can be uncertain in different ways. It fits that there are many different irrealis moods. The **subjunctive** mood is a general irrealis mood used most often in subordinate clauses that the speaker doubts, wishes were true, thinks are possible, doesn't think have happened yet...generally things that aren't concretely real. The **conditional** mood marks a statement which is only true when a certain condition is met. In English, the conditional is marked with an auxiliary verb, *would*, but it can also be marked morphologically. Here is an example of both from Spanish.

```
8. Si yo fuera rico, viajaria el mundo.  
   si yo fue-ra      rico viaj -aria el mundo  
   if 1s be -SBJ.PST.1s rich travel-CND.1s the world  
   "If I were rich, I'd travel the world."
```

This sentence implies that I'm not rich--counterfactuals tend to want an irrealis mood. It also says that me travelling the world is a hypothetical state that depends on something else. Neither is factual, both are irrealis.

Many languages have unique forms for commands. A mood used to command a listener to do something is the **imperative** mood. In addition to the imperative, some languages have a specific mood used to *forbid* an action, or command a listener not to do something, which is called the **prohibitive**. These forms are often defective: they might lack a third person form, and often have no first-person singular form because let's be honest, what's the point of commanding yourself to do something out loud?

Other kinds of irrealis moods can carry meaning similar to English auxiliary verbs. A mood marking that a statement is not necessarily true but that the speaker wants it to be true could be **optative** or **jussive** (think "I want X to happen" or "May X be done"). The **potential** voice marks that something is possible, like English "can." Generally moods can mark the chance or ability of something to happen as well as the speaker's attitude for it. There's often significant overlap between different categories, as they all blend into each other. As with all features, describe what the moods in your conlang do first, then name them.

Conclusion

Verbs are words that describe the action or state at the core of a sentence. They can take different numbers of arguments: intransitive verbs only have one, but transitive verbs have two. Verbs often agree with their arguments and mark categories such as tense and aspect, which have to do with when an event happened, or mood, which has to do with how a speaker feels about the truth of a statement.

So tell me, what do *your* conlang's verbs conjugate for? Do they agree with any arguments? What tenses, aspects, and moods are there? How do you use each one and how do they interact?